



A PRABHAKAR RAO

HYDERABAD | Grim Reminder

The murderous attack on unarmed policemen at a picket near Falaknuma Palace in Old Hyderabad on May 18 came as a grim reminder of the Mecca Masjid bomb blast exactly two years ago. Two gunmen calmly walked up to the picket and opened fire, killing a constable as he ran to call for help. Another was injured. Nine people had died in the mosque blast on May 18, 2007 and another five were killed when the police opened fire to quell violent mobs in the aftermath of the explosion. The police say the gunmen left a pamphlet at the site of the incident. Claiming to be from a group called Tehreek-e-Jalwa-e-Islam, the attackers said their act was in retaliation to the police firing two years ago and warned that there was more to come. Six bullet casings and two live rounds were recovered, indicating the use of small arms like 7.65 mm pistols. Bystanders watched in mute horror as the killers drove up on a scooter, fired at the police and sped away. The attack came at a time when the city had already been under a high alert for three days, under threat of a terror attack. "It is too early to draw any conclusion," says Police Commissioner B. Prasada Rao. He did not, however, rule out the possibility of the attack being the handiwork of a Lashkar-e-Toiba activist, Vikaruddin, who had fired at a counter-intelligence team of the city police five months ago.

THE KILLING IN HYDERABAD OCCURRED EVEN AS THE CITY WAS UNDER HIGH ALERT FOLLOWING A TERROR THREAT

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people were killed in the Mecca Masjid blast on May 18, 2007, and five others died in subsequent police firing to control violent mobs.

by Amarnath K. Menon